You can host a static website with S3 and deliver static content like HTML, JavaScript, CSS, images (such as PNG and JPG), audio, and videos. Keep in mind, however, that you can't execute server-side scripts like PHP or JSP. For example, it's not possible to host WordPress, a content management system based on PHP, on S3.

Increasing speed by using a CDN

Using a content-delivery network (CDN) helps reduce the load time for static web content. A CDN distributes static content like HTML, CSS, and images to nodes all around the world. If a user sends out a request for some static content, the request is answered from the nearest available node with the lowest latency. Various providers offer CDNs. Amazon CloudFront is the CDN offered by AWS. When using CloudFront, users connect to CloudFront to access your content, which is fetched from S3 or other sources. See the CloudFront documentation at http://mng.bz/M0m8 if you want to set this up; we won't cover it in this book.

In addition, S3 offers the following features for hosting a static website:

- *Defining a custom index document and error documents*—For example, you can define index.xhtml as the default index document.
- *Defining redirects for all or specific requests*—For example, you can forward all requests from /img/old.png to /img/new.png.
- *Setting up a custom domain for an S3 bucket*—For example, Andreas might want to set up a domain like mybucket.andreaswittig.info pointing to his bucket.

7.6.1 Creating a bucket and uploading a static website

First you need to create a new S3 bucket. To do so, open your terminal and execute the following command, replacing `$BucketName` with your own bucket name. As we've mentioned, the bucket name has to be globally unique. If you want to link your domain name to S3, you must use your entire domain name as the bucket name: